These were clearly the thoughts of the older Padshah, a father whose daughters were cherished above all, and who now, after a more tempestuous youth, had the sobriety and sensitivity to see in all young women his own daughters' faces.

In 1593, Akbar recalled to Lahore another old family member, one who had not been seen at court for a worrisome number of years.* Mirza Aziz Koka, capricious and outspoken on many occasions, had stormed out of the court some years previously muttering about the need to grow his beard, unhappy with the liberties Akbar was taking with Islam. Now Akbar summoned him from his subah of Gujarat but Aziz Koka, pretending to be marching against the Portuguese at Diu, prepared to board a hajj ship and make his way to Mecca.

Brought up an orthodox Muslim man, Aziz Koka had long been critical of the 'innovations' at Akbar's court, and those persons that he blamed for encouraging the Padshah in this disastrous direction. In this court Islam was not accorded preference, and the Padshah said to his mother that in the spirit of sulh kul, 'the contempt of any religion is the contempt of God'. This would have been a galling point of view for Aziz Koka, not made more palatable by Akbar's questioning of Islam being the sole repository of religious truth when he said that 'truth inhabited every religion…how was it then that one religion and one community that was relatively young—it had not been around even for a thousand years—should receive preference at the expense of others?'

Naturally this challenge was also directed at Hinduism, but it was never really perceived as such, perhaps because no Hindu sect felt the need to respond to the Padshah's enquiry. Sulh kul was primarily seen as a questioning of orthodox Islam, and the supremacy vested in the ulema. Certainly, a letter that Akbar wrote to Murad at this time would give a great deal more to an orthodox Islamic man to be circumspect about:

> Devotion to the Matchless One (Bechun) is beyond the limits of the spoken word whether in respect of form (jism), material attributes (jismanaiat), letter (harf), or sound (saut). Devotion to the Matchless One is (also) matchless.

Scholars have remarked that these thoughts were rather more reminiscent of the Nirguna Bhakti saints such as Kabir and Guru Nanak than in keeping with orthodox Islam. In another letter to Murad, who asked for direction